ART

ART AND THE CITY

***DAG**'s annual art and heritage festival will debut in Mumbai with a multi-site programme*

After four editions in Kolkata, DAG's art and heritage festival, The City as a Museum, will open in Mumbai with a lineup of exhibitions, talks, walks, workshops and a final iftaar feast. Held over two weeks, the festival will travel to historic sites and lesser-known spaces such as artists' homes and personal archives and collections.

Ashish Anand, CEO and MD of DAG, says, "With four editions of The City as a Museum in Kolkata behind us, we wanted to explore other cities through the same platform, and Mumbai was the logical choice given its extraordinary heritage sites and diverse and vibrant communities and cultures. Even from a purely pedagogical exercise, Kolkata and Mumbai are the two cities most closely linked with the development of pre-modern and modern Indian art."

Art, photos, documents and letters show how methods of teaching art evolved over the years

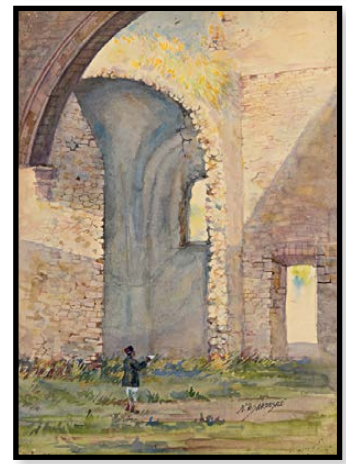
The inaugural exhibition in collaboration with Sir JJ School of Art titled *Shifting Visions: Teaching Modern Art at the Bombay School* is a groundbreaking exercise in bringing together never-before-seen material from the School as well as DAG. It features artworks as well as photographs, documents and letters to highlight how methods for teaching evolved through the years and explores the impetus for the shift in focus from craft and industry towards the cultivation of fine arts.

Other highlights include a walkthrough of the extraordinary murals at the School with artist and head of the painting department, Dr Douglas John, to explore the central role of mural painting in the formation of modern art in the city; a visit to the Elephanta Caves with art historian Dr Giles Tillotson to understand how artists drew inspiration from it and its influence on modern art; and a workshop rethinking the practice of drawing through colonial-era art with artists Snehal Pradhan and Soumava Das. "A major challenge was the research, where we had to identify objects, spaces, people and dig deeper into their stories, as we wanted to focus on spaces and narratives that have not been publicly showcased before," says Anand. The festival will also include a talk by art scholar Dr Saryu Doshi on the transformative impact of teaching and learning Indian art, a round-table discussion on research and its role in artistic practice, and a talk and workshop at the Dr Bhau Daji Lad Mumbai City Museum by Tasneem Zakaria Mehta and Kaiwan Mehta. "The penultimate event at the iconic painting studio Alfred Talkies—with which the Progressive artists M.F. Husain and Tyeb Mehta were associated—also promises to be special and will reveal lesser-known aspects of these artists," adds Anand. ■

–Prachi Joshi

The City as a Museum will be held across various venues in Mumbai from March 7 to 23







IN A DREAM TOWN (clockwise from top) 'The Garden of the Director's Residence, Sir J.J. School of Art' by Charles Gerrard; P.T. Reddy's self portrait; an untitled work by N.R. Sardesai